military in Cuba. “He considered this a more important consideration than the IL-28 bombers,” reads the summary of the meeting. McCone was particularly uneasy about SAM missiles that could shoot down U-2 planes and thereby allow the reintroduction of nuclear missiles to Cuba.

The Joint Chiefs of Staff, with whom Kennedy met that day, were of the same opinion, concerned not only about the remaining SAMs but also about Soviet MiG fighters. They reiterated their standard solution to the problem: invasion. The chiefs informed the president that the armed forces were “in an optimum posture to execute” the invasion. They added, knowing Kennedy’s deep-seated concern about Berlin, “We are not only ready to take any action you may order in Cuba, we are also in an excellent condition world-wide to counter any Soviet military response to such action.”[1]

The next ExCom meeting, on November 19, one day prior to the announced presidential press conference, showed that the ranks of the optimists regarding a possible deal with the Soviets were shrinking dramatically. Khrushchev remained silent on the thirty-day deadline. The note-taker recorded Dean Rusk as saying, “We have received no word yet from Khrushchev.” Rusk reported on the continuing negotiations with Vasilii Kuznetsov in New York, but Kuznetsov was indicating no change in the Kremlin’s usual position. Time, however, was becoming an ever more urgent issue not only because of the forthcoming press conference but also because the suspension of American overflights, now dangerous in view of Castro’s threats, had left the Americans in the dark with regard to the latest developments in Cuba.

Kennedy authorized high-level U-2 missions over the island but ordered a delay in the resumption of low-level missions. “President reluctant to send in low level flights,” scribbled Robert Kennedy on a sheet of White House letterhead. “Major prob[lem] what all this does in USSR-China conflict. How far can we push K[hrushchev].” Still, JFK could not postpone low-level flights indefinitely. He asked his military to get ready to resume such flights on Wednesday, November 24. With no positive response from Khrushchev and Castro’s standing order to shoot at low-level reconnaissance planes, losses of the planes and pilots were to be expected. Kennedy wanted to look into “military actions to be taken in retaliation for